



Comeback man: Pardeep Narwal made his return to the Bengaluru Bulls, the franchise that launched his PKL career in season 2.

"Young kabaddi players today are more professional than ever before. They train year-round, prioritise fitness, and focus on recovery and nutrition. The financial rewards from the PKL have significantly contributed to this increased professionalism," says UP Yoddhas coach Jasveer Singh to *Sportstar*.

Pardeep Narwal, the poster boy of PKL who holds most of the raiding records, has been roped in by Bengaluru Bulls for a mere ₹70 lakhs. Dubki King, as his moniker goes, hasn't enjoyed the best of outings in recent seasons, but the Bulls will be hoping Narwal can turn things around under the tutelage of the league's longest-serving coach, Randhir Singh Sehrawat, who gave him his PKL debut back in season two.

This feels less like a romantic

homecoming for Narwal and more like a last chance to prove himself. If he can't overcome his fitness challenges and perform on the mat, he risks becoming a mere squad filler and marketing tool before ultimately vanishing into obscurity like the erstwhile superstars.

Kabaddi evolution

Since its establishment in 2014, the league has transformed the ancient Indian sport into a televised spectacle, elevating its athleticism and engaging audiences.

Over the past decade, it has witnessed a remarkable progression, with squads comprised of younger, fitter athletes. These developments have paved the way for innovative tactics and strategies, revolutionising the game as we know it.

Paltan's triumph last season was not merely a show of superiority. On its way to the summit, it also revolutionised the way the game is played. Its blitzkrieg style blurred the lines between attack and defence,

Fact file



Season 1 - 2014

No. of matches - 60 (56 league matches and five playoff matches)
No. of venues - 8
Most expensive player - Rakesh Kumar (₹12.80 lakhs, Patna Pirates)



Season 2 - 2015

No. of matches - 60 (56 league matches and five playoff matches)
No. of venues - 8
Most expensive player - Hadi Oshtorak (₹21.1 lakhs, Telugu Titans)



Season 3 - January 2016

No. of matches - 60 (56 league matches and five playoff matches)
No. of venues - 8
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Season 4 - June 2016

No. of matches - 60 (56 league matches and five playoff matches)
No. of venues - 8
Most expensive player - Mohit Chhillar (₹53 lakhs, Bengaluru Bulls)



Season 5 - 2017

No. of matches - 138 (132 league matches and 6 playoff matches)
No. of venues - 12
Most expensive player - Nitin Tomar (₹93 lakhs, UP Yoddhas)



Season 6 - 2018

No. of matches - 138 (132 league matches and 6 playoff matches)
No. of venues - 12
Most expensive player - Monu Goyat (₹1.51 crore, Haryana Steelers)